

Brand Strategy Checklist

A step-by-step checklist to pressure-test your brand strategy before you spend a single franc on execution.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Business owners and marketing leads about to brief a designer, launch a new offer, or go into a rebrand — who want the strategic groundwork solid before anyone opens a design file.

HOW TO USE IT

Work through each section as a gate. Don't move to the next section — and don't move to visual identity work — until every box in the current one is checked. Use it alone first, then again with your team.

1. FOUNDATIONS

If you can't check these five, nothing built on top of your strategy will hold.

[] We can name our target customer specifically — not just a broad demographic like "young professionals."

[] We have a one-sentence description of what business we're actually in.

[] We know who else our customer could choose instead of us.

Direct competitors, indirect substitutes, and "doing nothing" all count.

[] We can state our single biggest point of difference in one sentence, without hedging.

[] We have at least one piece of real evidence that backs that difference up.

2. MARKET REALITY

Strategy built on assumptions instead of evidence tends to fail expensively, after the identity is already built.

[] We've talked to real customers about why they chose us, or didn't.

Not guessed. Actual conversations, even five of them.

[] We know our pricing relative to the two or three alternatives our customers actually compare us against.

[] We understand what's changing in our market that could affect this positioning over the next 12 months.

3. INTERNAL ALIGNMENT

A strategy that only lives in the founder's head isn't a strategy the business can execute.

- [] Everyone on the team could repeat our positioning in their own words, not recite it word for word.
- [] Our current pricing, offer, and messaging don't quietly contradict the strategy we just wrote down.
- [] Leadership has signed off on the strategy in writing — not just nodded in a meeting.

4. READY FOR DESIGN & EXECUTION

This is the gate before you brief anyone on visuals.

- [] We have a documented brand strategy — a real document, not ideas scattered across someone's head and old chat threads.
- [] We know what's off-brand for us — what we will say no to, not only what we stand for.
- [] We have budget and timeline agreed before briefing a designer, so the strategy doesn't get compromised by a rushed execution.

SCORING

Checked fewer than 8 of 13 boxes? Go back to Sections 1 and 2 before spending on identity or campaign work. A strategy with real gaps gets far more expensive to fix after the logo, website, or packaging is already designed around it.

NEXT STEPS

A brand strategy is a working document, not a plaque on the wall — revisit it every time the market, the offer, or the competitive set shifts meaningfully. Once every box here is checked, you're ready to brief a designer with the Strategic Design Brief, or move straight into the Brand Identity Checklist.